

Stranger at HOME

Aatish Taseer's first novel brings out the tensions and temptations of modern India

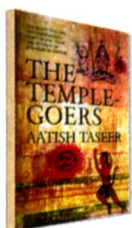


| By S. Prasannarajan |

What we hear in the rustle of the pages that make the Indian Writing in English the most productive enterprise in contemporary literature is a familiar anger. The same shared dissent. The same social earnestness that unites the original and the pretender. The same rejoinder to the wretchedness that is India, a country where the bloodlust of tradition is matched by the hatred that pervades the present. The same joylessness of being Indian. Then you hear this, a cry of denial from the narrator of *The Temple-Goers*: "I envy the fact that when the world becomes his, which it will have to, or none of what we're saying has any meaning, he will be able to put his hand straight in the fire, with his language, his religion, his idea of who he is, intact and close around him. And people like me, who never played any part in rejecting these things, who

inherited this rejection from the generations before us, will have no place in that world. What I feel when I see him is something like a nostalgia for a childhood I never lived. But it's not really childhood I'm craving; I didn't realise that until now. It's the cultural wholeness you spoke earlier of, the security of which I have, in my mind, substituted with the security of childhood."

The narrator's name is Aatish Taseer, and it's the name that appears on the cover of this first novel as well. He is talking about his personal trainer, Aakash Sharma, a Brahmin who strikes a fine balance between his ancestral obligations, which are steeped in the rites and rituals of his caste, and his life in the suburban thrills of Sectorpur and Phasenagar. The rhyming intonation of their first names is not the only thing that brings out their intimacy, the homoeroticism in their relationship is accentuated by their cultural incompatibilities as well: the solidity of Aakash set against the fluidity of Aatish, the



THE TEMPLE-
GOERS

by AATISH TASEER
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